

Arguing A Position

Context

Purpose: Essay 1 will allow you to practice useful skills needed to construct effective, well evidenced arguments. This essay will task you with taking a clear position on a well-presented, controversial issue of your choosing. Your goal for this essay is to demonstrate to your reader the validity of your position by using effective rhetorical strategies (ethos, pathos, and logos) relying on reliable researched sources to support your argument. Your essay must also effectively address opposing view points to your position.

Before writing and submitting a final essay, you will write a topic proposal (where you will briefly describe the issue you are going to write about and your specific position) & a short annotated bibliography (this will contain the MLA citation information for your 3 sources, as well as a short analytical summary of each source, including how you intend on using it in your essay). Specific details on these process work activities will be provided later on, but these assignments will be graded and count towards the projects overall point total.

Assignment Requirements

Chapter 6 (page 191) and Chapter 16 (page 505) of *The St. Martin's Guide to Writing* explain how to write an Arguing a Position essay with a focused thesis that avoids traps like logical fallacies.

Essay 1's objectives will show that you can:

1. Select an appropriate controversial issue: The "issue" you choose to write about must be current and relevant. In addition, the issue you choose must be one that can be argued against, meaning you must choose a topic that is a matter of opinion. You will basically be arguing where you stand on this topic.
2. Write a position argument research essay: While you will be arguing your personal position on an issue based on your opinions, first-hand experience, and observations, it is also a requirement that your argument include researched, reliable sources that you locate and read online. I encourage you to use UCR's library databases as much as possible, but you can also use internet sources as long as you think carefully and verify the reliability of your sources. Specifically, you must have 3 researched sources in this

essay—two that act as supporting evidence for your position and one that acts as a counterargument for the opposing position.

3. Include supporting claims and counterarguments: While your essay will be focused on your position, you will also strategically describe and respond to opposing views on your chosen issue. This is a very powerful strategy in argumentation. Although you will be providing this counterargument, remember that your ultimate goal is to spin this opposing view in a way that makes it actually support your position.

General Info & Deadlines

- Strict MLA formatting (12 point, Times New Roman font, double-spaced) required—see Ch. 20 of *The St. Martin's Guide*.
- In addition to the official UWP rubric, I will assess your essay using the requirements detailed in this prompt.
- Paper length minimum: 1500 words, not including MLA heading info or Works Cited pages.
- Project Grade Breakdown: Annotated Bibliography (20 points), Final Essay (180 points).
- Due dates: See the Schedule on Canvas!

The St. Martin's Guide to Writing Essay Checklist

- ☐ Choose a controversial issue on which to take a position on pages 221-222
- ☐ Test your topic on pages 222-223
- ☐ Frame the issue for your readers on pages 223-224
- ☐ Test your choice on page 224
- ☐ Formulate a working thesis stating your position on pages 224-225
- ☐ Develop the reasons supporting your position on page 225
- ☐ Research your position on page 226

❑ Use sources to reinforce your credibility on pages 226-227

❑ Identify and respond to likely objections on pages 227-229

Overview	Exceeds Expectations	Meets Expectations	Nearly Meets Expectations	Does Not Meet Expectations
Focused, Well-presented Issue	Introduction is well written, directed, appropriate, and clearly and concisely provides the main points of the argument. Thesis is clear and effective.	Introduction is directed, appropriate, and prepares readers for the topic and argument. The summary is limited or too broad, but focused. Some background of the topic Clearly presents a thesis.	Introduction gets the reader to the thesis, but thesis may not make an argument. It is appropriate, but may be under-developed or provide too much summary. The main points are present but may be too general.	Introduction lacks focus. May be vague or off-topic. Missing thesis.
Clear, Logical Organization	Effective and creative. Arguments and counter-argument are well organized and make sense with the thesis. Arguments are supported with sources/evidence and analysis. Includes effective transitions. Conclusion is effectively placed and reiterates significance and argument.	Coherent. Arguments and counter-argument are appropriately organized, and support thesis. Arguments supported with sources/ evidence. Paragraphs are usually an appropriate length. Essay interesting, for the most part, though may lag in places. Conclusion is appropriate.	Organization attempted, but Arguments may be unclear in some places or may not effectively support thesis. Sources may lack analysis. Paragraphs may be focused but might oversimplify/ summarize points and may not clearly transition. Includes opposing argument. Conclusion just repeats what came before.	Organization unclear. Essay rambles. Arguments points may be misplaced, mismatched or unidentified. Supporting evidence lacks order and analysis. Essay may oversimplify or summarize points. Points may be disconnected or unbalanced. Conclusion may be missing or no opposing argument present.

Effective Response to Opposing Views	Effectively identifies and responds to opposing views. Explanation of opposing view is respectful and thorough. Counter argues by conceding, refuting, or a combination.	Opposing view explained. Counter argument includes concession, refutation, or a combination.	Mentions an opposing view. Explanation is limited or missing. Does not counter argue .	Opposing view missing or mentioned dismissively. No counterargument.
Smooth Integration of Sources	The writer uses sources in clear and effective ways. Sources are credible and provide clear support to the argument. Use of sources provides a balance between paraphrasing and direct quotation. Sources are integrated smoothly into writer's text and are fully introduced and analyzed. Sources cited are properly formatted and are entered on the works cited page.	The writer uses sources in clear and effective ways. Sources are credible and provide relevant support. Provides some balance between paraphrasing and direct quotation (may lean too much on one side). Sources are integrated into writer's text, but may be clumsily done at times or not fully analyzed. Sources are properly cited entered on the works cited page.	The writer uses sources but may not be effective. Sources are may not provide clear support to the arguments. Citations of sources may reveal superficial or incomplete research. Quoted material is may not be appropriately integrated into writer's text. Author may rely too much or too little on quoted material and not analysis. Sources are properly cited and there is a complete works cited page.	One or more sources are missing or writer does not integrate sources. Sources are inappropriate, dated, or peripheral to the arguments. Quotes are not smoothly integrated and appear usually as "drop quotes" or filler. Essay is missing speaker tags or credentials for cited material. Sources are not appropriately cited or not analyzed. Work cited lacking or missing.

Grammar & Style	The writer uses precise, expressive language, which includes appropriate rhetorical strategies. Vivid vocabulary and an active voice to energize the topic. Essay includes a variety of sophisticated sentence structures. Sentences are free from major grammatical errors. No major punctuation problems or typos.	Clear sentences and accurate vocabulary engage the reader in the topic. The writer attempts to use active voice. The essay includes a variety of sentence structures. Sentences have only a couple of major grammatical errors and no pervasive pattern of error. The essay may include some punctuation problems or typographical errors.	Sentences show mostly accurate vocabulary. This essay may contain minor problems in grammar, punctuation, or word choice, which distract the reader but do not get in the way of ideas or comprehension. Sentences show some variation of structure and style. May overuse passive voice.	Sentences are very simple, showing little to no variation in structure. The essay contains serious grammatical errors, making the essay difficult to understand at times. Word choices are very repetitive or frequently inaccurate.
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Comments: